

Chapter

Veda and Vedanta — The Journey of Knowing and Its End



Introduction: What Is the Veda?

Ask which is the root scripture of Sanatan Dharma, and we at once say: **the Veda**. But what is the Veda, really? In this discourse Acharya Upendra Ji begins with exactly this question and breaks a common assumption:

"What do you think the Veda is, some kind of book? Is it a book? How many of you think the Veda is a book, some scripture? Alright. Let me show you that this too is a misconception."

As Sanatanis, he says, this much we should certainly know:

"We call ourselves Sanatanis, all of us Hindus, so at the very least we should know about our own scripture."

This chapter follows that understanding step by step: **what the Veda is, how it kept growing, where Vedanta comes in, and what Upanishad means.**

1. The Veda Is Not a Noun but a Verb

Acharya Ji asks a simple question of grammar: is Veda a name or an action?

"Veda — is it a name or an action? That is, is it a noun or is it a verb?"

And he answers:

"So the Veda is not a noun, not a book. It is not a book, it is an action. That action — '**aham veda**', I have known. The process of knowing is called Veda."

In Sanskrit the root **vid** means **to know**; "**aham veda**" means "I know." So the Veda is not an object but **the process of knowing**. And knowing what?

"Veda means knowing. Knowing what? The knowledge of this world and the world beyond. All the knowledge of this place, which I come to know slowly, slowly — and going on, what will happen after death, what lies ahead, what I will become, whether there will be moksha, what the next birth will be — all knowledge up to that point. Spiritual knowledge, knowledge of this world here — what is it called? Veda."

2. Apaurusheya and the Divine Word

The Vedas are called **apaurusheya**, meaning not composed by any one person. They are also called **devavani**, the speech

of the gods. Acharya Ji links both to "aham brahmāsmi" (I am Brahman):

"It is called apaurusheya — no single person wrote it. And it is also called devavani. So is every person a deva or not? Is there Brahman in every one or not? 'Aham brahmāsmi.'"

If Brahman is in every person, then what every person comes to know is also part of that divine word. This is why Acharya Ji sees the Veda as a boundless vessel:

"So think of the Veda as one whole big box. Suppose a container, a big vessel, whose size is infinite."

3. Knowledge of All Three Gunas Is in the Veda

What does this boundless vessel hold? Acharya Ji shows a verse from the Bhagavad Gita:

**traiguṇya-viṣayā vedā nistraiguṇyo bhavārjuna,
nirdvandvo nitya-sattva-stho niryoga-kṣema
ātmavān.**

"The Vedas deal with the subjects of the three gunas; O Arjuna, rise above the three gunas — free from the pairs of opposites, ever established in sattva, free from concern for acquiring and keeping (yoga-kshema), and established in the Self."

— Bhagavad Gita 2.45

The three gunas are **sattva** (purity, knowledge), **rajas** (desire, activity) and **tamas** (inertia, ignorance). Acharya Ji says the world has all three kinds of people, and all of them are searching for the same thing:

"There are three types of people in the world. Tamasic people too must be babbling something; Brahman is in them too."

"Because finally everyone is looking for bliss — everybody is seeking happiness."

Chapters on tamasic pleasure too

So every form of pleasure will be described somewhere in the Veda, the tamasic form included:

"Someone said — eat a lot, eat your fill, eat pizza, eat everything — and you get bliss. So a chapter on that too will come into the Veda. Somewhere in some Veda there will be something on that too, with its phalashruti and all."

"Someone will write: drink liquor, keep drinking this much, then bliss comes. Somewhere in the Atharvaveda you will find all such chapters, phalashruti and everything."

"After that someone will say — no, not one, there should be four or five women, affairs, lust — that will bring bliss. Somewhere in the Vedas you will find chapters of desire for that too. Because that is for fulfilling tamasic people."

Phalashruti is the description of the fruit gained from a certain act or recitation. Acharya Ji's point is that what Brahman itself came to know in the form of a person in a tamasic state also becomes part of this apaurusheya knowledge.

Rajasic and sattvic views too

But other views are added to the same vessel:

"Then there are rajasic people here too, and sattvic people too, aren't there? So then someone will write — a doctor will also write in it — 'Yes, but if you drink this much liquor your liver gets damaged; don't do this and that; such and such diet is needed.' That too will then come into the Vedas."

"Did you understand or not — how the Veda got developed? Going on like this, all the knowledge of the whole world is in it."

4. The Veda Never Ends

If the Veda is the process of knowing, can it ever stop? Acharya Ji says no:

"All the knowledge that was collected — that is '**kālāya tasmai namaḥ**'. So the Veda never ends. Has the act of knowing come to an end even today? Today you are doing something with a computer — that new knowledge also is part of the Veda, actually."

The texts we read under the name of the Vedas are only an essence of this endless knowledge:

"But to understand something, we read its essence in a book — there are names like Yajurveda, Atharvaveda — so only an extract of it has been given. Otherwise the Veda never ends — it keeps on adding."

"Like that, some new invention will come today, and from that angle too some people benefit. So everything is part of the Veda."

5. Vedanta: Where Knowing Is Complete

If everything is Veda, then who has the last word? Acharya Ji points to the rishis, munis and avatars:

"So then, at the last, some rishi or muni must also have written, no? There would be some avatars, they too must have written something, no? So will that be final or not? Their statement is final."

And what is their final word?

"So what they would have written — 'Leave all this above, all this is moha-maya (attachment and illusion)' — so the sentences the rishis and munis wrote at the last, there the Veda ends. There are no teachings beyond that."

This is where the meaning of the word **Vedanta** opens up: **Veda** + **anta** (end):

"So that part is called as Vedanta — the end of the Vedas comes here. It means the process of knowing has ended here. There is nothing more to understand beyond that."

The book that says, "Don't read me"

Acharya Ji says something startling:

"So the Veda is the only book which shouts and tells, 'Don't read me.' You won't believe it — 'Don't read me.'"

Its basis is that same word of the Gita — **nistraiguṇyo bhavārjuna**:

"What Krishna said — '**nistraiguṇyo bhavārjuna**' — leave all that of the three gunas first, what is beyond it, that is, read from the last part. If you want to read, what should you read? Vedanta."

6. Moksha for the Jnani: Knowledge in Every Path

Acharya Ji calls Vedanta the **jnana kanda** (the section of knowledge), and explains the scriptural saying "moksha is for the jnani (the knower)":

"Vedanta is called as the **jnana kanda**. It is said, 'Moksha for the jnani.' What does moksha for the jnani mean? Not going to school and becoming a pandit ji."

Knowledge is not the matter of one path alone. In all four paths — **karma yoga**, **bhakti yoga**, **jnana yoga**, **dhyana yoga** — knowledge is the foundation:

- **Karma yoga:**

"You want to do karma? Work is worship — fine. But do karma joined with knowledge. Understand the result of what you are doing, understand why you are doing it. Get the knowledge from the Guru."

- **Bhakti yoga:**

"You want to do bhakti? Don't have blind faith; do bhakti joined with knowledge. First understand the Narada Bhakti Sutras and so on properly. Who were the gopis, who was Radha — first know all this. What is bhakti — first understand it, then do it. Don't do just anything at your own whim, even bhakti, according to the three gunas."

- **Jnana yoga:**

"If it is knowledge itself you want to gain — jnana yoga — gain that too the way a jnani does."

- **Dhyana yoga:**

"If you want to meditate, don't go and sit in the Himalayas to get your photo taken. On what to meditate — take knowledge for that too, and then do it."

So "jnani" means a **tattva-jnani**, one who seeks to understand the fundamental truth:

"So that is why it is said — moksha for the jnani. Tattva-jnani — first try to understand tattva-jnana."

7. Karma Kanda, Upasana Kanda, Jnana Kanda

Acharya Ji gives the order of the three sections of the Veda:

"So Vedanta is nothing but the jnana kanda. So what will all the rest be before it? The upasana kanda, and before that will be the karma kanda. In the karma kanda there is only puja-path, all that, our yajna and so on."

- **Karma kanda** — rituals such as puja-path and yajna
- **Upasana kanda** — worship and spiritual practice
- **Jnana kanda** — Vedanta, the final knowledge

8. Upanishad: Sitting Close to the Guru

This jnana kanda is what is called the **Upanishad**. Acharya Ji opens up the word:

"So this jnana kanda itself is converted into a word called Upanishad. Upa + ni + shad — sit close below the Guru. Such a vidya (knowledge) — going near the Guru, sitting below him."

Upa = near, ni = below, shad = to sit. But this is not only physical closeness:

"And what else? In a sattvic state. That means with sharanagati. Near means learning like this, understanding his words from the heart."

Sharanagati, complete surrender to the Guru, is the state in which the knowledge of Vedanta descends.

Summary: Key Teachings

- 1 The Veda is not a book but an action** — "**aham veda**", I have known. The process of knowing itself is the Veda.
- 2 The Veda is knowledge of this world and the world beyond** — from this world up to death, rebirth and moksha.

- 3 **The Veda is apaurusheya and the divine word —**
Brahman is in every person, so all that is known is part of that boundless vessel.
- 4 **The Veda holds knowledge of all three gunas —**
tamasic, rajasic and sattvic, because **everybody is seeking happiness.**
- 5 **The Veda never ends — it keeps on adding;** the texts we read are only its essence.
- 6 **Vedanta means the end of the Vedas —** the final word of the rishis, munis and avatars, beyond which there is nothing to know. **Nistraiguṇyo bhavārjuna** — if you want to read, read Vedanta.
- 7 **Moksha for the jnani —** all four paths, karma, bhakti, jnana and dhyana, must be joined with knowledge.
- 8 **Upanishad means sitting close to the Guru —** learning in a sattvic state, with surrender, understanding from the heart.